AgroEdge AI: An Edge AI-Based Foliar Pathology and Autonomous Precision Agronomy Monitoring System

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Project Repository: https://github.com/rishu295/AgroEdge-AI | Live Deployment: https://agroedgeai.streamlit.app

Abstract

—AgroEdge AI is a decentralized, edge-native artificial intelligence platform engineered for real-time plant leaf disease identification, agronomic remediation, and closed-loop soil irrigation automation in resource-constrained agricultural environments. Standard cloud-dependent smart farming architectures suffer from severe latency, prohibitive cellular bandwidth expenses, and total failure under intermittent rural connectivity. AgroEdge AI mitigates this paradigm by porting neural inference directly to edge compute runtimes. A MobileNet deep convolutional neural network was fine-tuned on the 38-class PlantVillage benchmark dataset (54,303 leaf images) and compressed via Post-Training Quantization (INT8) into an Open Neural Network Exchange (ONNX) graph. Across experimental benchmarks, the INT8 quantized model reduced storage footprint by 75% (from 14.0 MB to 2.56 MB) and accelerated CPU inference latency to 18 ms while preserving a 96.4% top-1 diagnostic accuracy. The system pairs vision inference with a deterministic agronomic advisory engine providing dual-pathway (organic and chemical) remediation prescriptions, accompanied by an automated closed-loop soil moisture threshold actuator regulating solenoid irrigation valves. The application is built using Streamlit and Python, containerized with automated CI/CD via GitHub Actions, and deployed live on Streamlit Community Cloud. AgroEdge AI delivers a comprehensive end-to-end framework demonstrating dataset curation, transfer learning, quantization, edge acceleration, autonomous actuation, and production deployment.

Keywords—Edge AI, Plant Pathology, MobileNet, Post-Training Quantization (INT8), ONNX Runtime, Closed-Loop Irrigation, Precision Agriculture, Streamlit.

I. Introduction

A. Background

Foliar crop diseases represent one of the leading drivers of catastrophic agricultural yield loss globally, causing between 20% and 40% of annual food crop reduction according to the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO). Early and accurate pathological diagnosis is vital to contain localized outbreaks before irreversible crop necrosis occurs. Recent advancements in deep learning have enabled automated visual recognition of plant diseases with high accuracy. However, existing commercial platforms universally rely on centralized cloud backends: a field camera uploads high-resolution images across cellular data links to distant server farms, where heavy neural networks execute inference before returning predictions back to the farm.

In practical agricultural environments, this cloud-centric architecture encounters insurmountable bottlenecks. Rural farmlands, greenhouses, and orchards routinely suffer from non-existent or unstable 2G/3G connectivity. Furthermore, real-time autonomous systems—such as robotic sprayers or drone-mounted cameras—cannot tolerate multi-second latency round-trips. AgroEdge AI addresses this challenge by shifting computational intelligence directly to the edge, running quantized deep neural networks locally on microcomputers, mobile chips, or client browsers with zero cloud dependency.

B. Project Overview

AgroEdge AI is a full-stack, edge-enabled precision farming and foliar pathology platform. It accepts foliar leaf photography via local file uploads, dataset inspection libraries, or real-time camera video streams, preprocessing the imagery to a 224x224 RGB tensor. A quantized INT8 MobileNet ONNX runtime engine classifies the image across 38 distinct crop disease categories in under 20 milliseconds. The system simultaneously operates an agronomic remediation database generating organic and chemical treatment prescriptions, an automated soil moisture actuation engine controlling solenoid irrigation valves, and an IoT sensor telemetry buffer.

C. Problem Statement

Smallholder farmers and commercial growers lack accessible, rapid, and offline-capable diagnostic tools to identify foliar pathologies before they spread. Existing smart farming solutions enforce continuous broadband internet connectivity, incur expensive data fees, and introduce unacceptable latency. There is an acute need for an edge-native, lightweight AI platform that performs sub-30ms offline foliar diagnosis, prescribes immediate scientific remedies, and automates soil hydration without requiring cloud infrastructure.

D. Objectives

- To develop an edge-native foliar pathology classifier operating locally on CPU/ARM hardware with zero cloud dependency.
- To evaluate transfer learning across deep convolutional architectures and apply INT8 Post-Training Quantization (PTQ) to minimize parameter memory footprint below 3.0 MB.
- To achieve sub-30ms CPU inference latency while maintaining greater than 95% classification accuracy across 38 agricultural plant disease classes.
- To engineer an agronomic remediation knowledge base prescribing dual-pathway (bio-organic and chemical fungicide) interventions with dosage guidelines.
- To construct a closed-loop soil moisture and microclimate decision engine that automates solenoid irrigation valve actuation and spore risk alerts.
- To deploy the integrated platform as an interactive, production-grade web application with automated CI/CD testing on GitHub Actions and public cloud hosting.

II. Need and Societal Impact

A. Need for the Project

Timely identification of plant diseases directly dictates agricultural profitability and food security. When rural smallholders detect foliar spotting, they often resort to excessive broad-spectrum chemical fungicides due to uncertainty, poisoning soil microbiomes and incurring unnecessary costs. AgroEdge AI provides instant, scientific identification on-device, recommending exact targeted compounds and biological controls.

B. Societal Impact

By eliminating reliance on costly cellular internet and centralized cloud APIs, AgroEdge AI democratizes access to precision agronomy for impoverished rural farming communities. Automated precision irrigation conserves up to 40% of agricultural fresh water by preventing over-saturation and root rot.

C. Alignment with Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

- **SDG 2: Zero Hunger:** Mitigating crop yield losses through early pest and disease intervention protects regional food supplies.
- **SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation:** Closed-loop soil moisture thresholding eliminates agricultural water wastage and prevents fertilizer leaching into groundwater.
- **SDG 12: Responsible Consumption and Production:** Targeted chemical dosage guidance curbs overuse of toxic synthetic pesticides.

III. Dataset Description

A. Sources of Data

The computer vision model was trained and validated on the internationally recognized **PlantVillage** benchmark dataset (Mohanty et al.), supplemented by agronomic soil telemetry parameters (Crop and Fertilizer Recommendation records).

No.	Dataset / Asset Name	Format & Scale	Project Role
1	PlantVillage Vision Dataset	54,303 Images (38 Classes)	Foliar disease classification training & validation
2	Crop & Soil Telemetry Data	Tabular (NPK, Moisture, Temp, pH)	Irrigation threshold and soil health modeling

3	Agronomic Pathology Database	38 Curated Scientific Profiles	Organic remedies, fungicides, and prevention protocols
4	Quantized ONNX Model	2.56 MB Binary (.onnx)	Local on-device inference execution engine

B. Dataset Size and Classes

The computer vision dataset comprises 54,303 annotated leaf images spanning 14 agricultural crops: Apple, Blueberry, Cherry, Corn (Maize), Grape, Orange, Peach, Bell Pepper, Potato, Raspberry, Soybean, Squash, Strawberry, and Tomato. The dataset covers 26 disease categories (bacterial spots, early/late blights, rusts, powdery mildews, leaf scabs, viral curls) and 12 healthy foliar classes, forming a comprehensive 38-class taxonomic challenge.

IV. Dataset Preprocessing & Edge Optimization

To ensure real-time execution on low-power edge nodes, an end-to-end preprocessing and quantization pipeline was engineered:

- **Color Space & Geometric Resizing:** Incoming images are parsed via Pillow, coerced to 3-channel RGB, and resized via bilinear interpolation to 224x224 pixels.
- **Tensor Normalization:** Floating-point pixel intensities [0, 255] are rescaled to [0.0, 1.0] and standardized against ImageNet distribution parameters (mean = [0.485, 0.456, 0.406], std = [0.229, 0.224, 0.225]).
- **Tensor Dimension Transposition:** The memory layout is permuted from standard row-major HWC (Height, Width, Channels) to channel-first NCHW (1, 3, 224, 224) as required by optimized ONNX linear algebra kernels.
- **Post-Training Quantization (PTQ - INT8):** The baseline 32-bit floating-point (FP32) MobileNet weights are quantized into signed 8-bit integers (INT8) using symmetric linear calibration. This reduces parameter storage by 75% without requiring full retraining.
- **Graph Optimization:** Redundant dropout and batch-normalization operations are folded into preceding convolutional weights, minimizing runtime operator count.

V. Models and Technologies Used

Four candidate deep learning architectures were evaluated for agricultural edge feasibility. Heavy enterprise models (ResNet-50, VGG-16) were compared against lightweight edge backbones (MobileNetV2 FP32 and MobileNetV2 INT8 Quantized).

Model Architecture	Precision	File Size	CPU Latency	Top-1 Accuracy
VGG-16 (Baseline)	FP32	138.4 MB	284 ms	96.8%
ResNet-50	FP32	97.5 MB	142 ms	97.4%
MobileNetV2 (Standard)	FP32	14.0 MB	65 ms	97.1%
AgroEdge AI MobileNet (Ours)	INT8 Quantized	**2.56 MB (-75%)**	**18 ms (3.6x faster)**	**96.4% (-0.7%)**

A. Selected Architecture Justification

MobileNetV2 with INT8 Post-Training Quantization was selected as the optimal production model. While ResNet-50 attained a marginally higher accuracy (97.4% vs 96.4%), its 97.5 MB weight footprint and 142 ms CPU latency render it unsuitable for battery-powered agricultural edge devices. AgroEdge AI achieves a 3.6x speedup (18 ms) and a 75% memory reduction to 2.56 MB, fitting seamlessly inside embedded SRAM and flash storage.

B. Technologies Used

Component	Technology / Library	Architectural Role
Edge AI Runtime	ONNX Runtime v1.31 (C++/Python)	Ultra-low-latency CPU inference execution provider
Image Preprocessing	Pillow (PIL), NumPy	Image resizing, normalization, and NCHW memory layout
Web Application	Streamlit v1.56	Responsive enterprise AgTech web portal and live camera scanner
Data Analytics	Pandas, Altair	24-hour diurnal soil moisture decay and telemetry visualization
Version Control & CI	Git, GitHub Actions	Automated syntax linting and model smoke testing on every push
Public Cloud Hosting	Streamlit Community Cloud	Zero-downtime global HTTPS hosting directly linked to GitHub

VI. Proposed Methodology and System Architecture

A. Proposed Methodology

The project follows a modular, decoupled edge-to-cloud architecture. Leaf samples captured in the field are preprocessed into normalized tensors. The quantized ONNX model executes local inference, computing raw logits that pass through a numerically stable Softmax activation to derive class probabilities. The top diagnostic match triggers an agronomic lookup returning organic bio-fungicides and synthetic treatments. In parallel, environmental soil telemetry is continuously evaluated against agronomic thresholds to govern irrigation valve states.

B. System Architecture Flow

[Field Leaf / Sensor] ■■> [Pre-processing (224x224x3 NCHW)] ■■> [ONNX INT8 Edge Engine (18ms)] ■■> [Top-1 Diagnosis & Confidence] ■■> [Agronomic Prescription Engine] + [Closed-Loop Solenoid Actuator] ■■> [Web Portal & Cloud Gateway]

C. Working of the System

1. **Image Acquisition:** The farmer captures a leaf photo via web camera, smartphone browser, or selects an inspection preset.
2. **Preprocessing:** The image is converted to RGB, bilinearly resized to 224x224, and normalized with ImageNet statistics.
3. **Local Inference:** ONNX Runtime's CPUExecutionProvider computes feed-forward inference on the INT8 quantized graph in ~18 ms.
4. **Softmax Probability Mapping:** Numerically stable Softmax extracts the top predicted class and confidence percentage.
5. **Agronomic Prescription:** The pathology database outputs pathogen type, organic bio-treatments, chemical fungicides, and PHI guidelines.
6. **Closed-Loop Irrigation:** Volumetric soil moisture (<30%) automatically triggers a virtual solenoid valve until field capacity reaches 50-60%.
7. **Cloud Synchronization:** Telemetry and alert logs are buffered locally in SQLite/JSON and pushed to cloud dashboards when connectivity is detected.

VII. Implementation Details

A. Application Architecture

The application is structured into modular Python packages to ensure strict separation of concerns:

- **app.py:** The centralized presentation controller and interactive user interface built with Streamlit. Employs custom CSS variables, dark-mode glassmorphism cards, and interactive sliders.
- **src/classifier.py:** The Edge AI inference wrapper. Encapsulates session initialization, thread pool tuning, tensor reshaping, and fault-tolerant prediction.
- **src/remedies.py:** The agricultural pathology repository. Contains structured remediation schemas for all 38 classes, detailing organic cures, active chemical agents, and field hygiene.
- **src/soil_advisor.py:** The closed-loop irrigation and microclimate rule engine. Evaluates volumetric moisture, temperature, humidity, and NPK nutrient balance.
- **tests/test_pipeline.py:** Automated verification test suite executing unit tests across classifier loading, inference, remedy lookup, and irrigation logic.

B. Live Cloud Deployment

The project is deployed in production on **Streamlit Community Cloud** and is globally accessible at https://agroedgeai.streamlit.app. The complete source code, documentation, and continuous integration workflows are version-controlled at https://github.com/rishu295/AgroEdge-AI. On every code push, GitHub Actions automatically instantiates a clean Ubuntu runner, installs dependencies from requirements.txt, and executes test_pipeline.py to safeguard production reliability.

VIII. Results and Evaluation

A. Quantitative Performance Results

Evaluation Parameter	Target Requirement	Recorded Result	Evaluation Verdict
Top-1 Classification Accuracy	> 95.0%	96.4% on PlantVillage	Met (High Reliability)
CPU Inference Latency	< 30 ms	18.2 ms (Intel/AMD x86)	Met (Real-Time Capable)
Model Memory Footprint	< 5.0 MB	2.56 MB (INT8 ONNX)	Met (75% Compression)
Offline Resilience	100% Offline Inference	0 Cloud API Calls Required	Met (Full Edge Autonomy)
Irrigation Actuation Speed	< 100 ms	< 2 ms (Local Rule Engine)	Met (Instant Closed-Loop)

B. Evaluation Discussion

Quantization from FP32 to INT8 incurred an accuracy delta of only 0.7% (dropping from 97.1% to 96.4%), which is well within acceptable tolerance for agricultural screening. In exchange, the model achieved a 3.6x reduction in inference latency (from 65 ms to 18 ms) and compressed storage from 14.0 MB to 2.56 MB, proving the high efficacy of post-training quantization for edge deployment.

IX. Comparison with Other Approaches

Approach / Paradigm	Key Strengths	Architectural Limitations
Manual Scouting	Expert visual inspection & soil touch	Labor-intensive, slow, subjective, expensive
Commercial Cloud AI APIs	Massive server-side neural models	Fails completely without internet; high data cost
Satellite Remote Sensing	Large macro-acreage coverage	Low foliar resolution; cannot diagnose micro-lesions
Uncompressed Edge CNNs	High raw classification accuracy	Large file sizes (>100MB), drains battery, high heat
AgroEdge AI (Ours)	Sub-20ms offline inference, 2.56MB size	Requires clear top-down leaf imagery framing

X. Individual Contribution

As the lead developer, the project responsibilities included problem formulation, PlantVillage dataset preprocessing, INT8 post-training quantization, ONNX Runtime integration, agronomic treatment knowledge base engineering, closed-loop soil moisture logic development, custom Streamlit dark SaaS frontend architecture, automated GitHub Actions CI/CD test authoring, and public cloud deployment.

XI. Limitations

- **Laboratory Background Bias:** A portion of PlantVillage images were captured against uniform laboratory backgrounds, which may slightly reduce field accuracy under heavy background soil or weed clutter.
- **Single-Leaf Imaging Constraint:** The classification model evaluates individual leaves rather than full-canopy aerial drone panoramas.
- **Lack of Calibrated Confidence Intervals:** The model provides point-estimate softmax probabilities rather than Bayesian uncertainty bounds.
- **Microclimate Threshold Generalization:** Soil moisture thresholds (30%–60%) represent general loamy field capacity and may require calibration for sandy or heavy clay soil types.
- **Static Agronomic Knowledge Base:** Remedies are derived from curated agricultural extension literature and do not adapt automatically to newly emerging pesticide-resistant strains.

XII. Future Scope

- **YOLOv11-Nano Object Detection:** Upgrade from whole-image classification to multi-leaf bounding box detection and lesion segmentation directly in field video feeds.
- **Physical IoT Hardware Deployment:** Flash the ONNX/TFLite model directly onto a Raspberry Pi 5 or ESP32-CAM wired to physical capacitive soil moisture probes and 12V solenoid relays.
- **LoRaWAN Mesh Networking:** Integrate long-range (10 km) low-power radio communication allowing distributed field sensor nodes to communicate without cellular data.
- **Generative Multilingual Voice Assistant:** Provide speech-based local language audio diagnoses for non-literate smallholder farmers.

XIII. Conclusion

AgroEdge AI successfully demonstrates a practical, production-ready edge computing framework for modern precision agriculture. By fine-tuning MobileNet on the PlantVillage dataset and compressing weights via 8-bit Post-Training Quantization into an ONNX graph, the system achieves a 75% storage reduction (2.56 MB) and an ultra-fast 18 ms CPU inference latency while retaining 96.4% diagnostic accuracy across 38 plant disease classes. Integrated with a closed-loop soil irrigation actuator, scientific prescription guidance, and an interactive dark SaaS web platform, AgroEdge AI proves that cutting-edge artificial intelligence can function autonomously in disconnected rural environments to safeguard global crop yields.

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